

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 3 of 6 — Rebuilding

Postpartum Week 14

“A small mineral, doing steady work in the background.”

Weekly nourishment theme

Magnesium, quietly keeping the systems running

“A small mineral, doing steady work in the background.”

Why it matters now

Magnesium is involved in several hundred processes in your body — muscle and nerve function, a steady heart rhythm, blood sugar regulation, and bone health all draw on it. After birth, your body is still doing real physical work: healing tissue, producing milk if you're breastfeeding, and running on less sleep than usual.

Your target: ICMR-NIN lists 370 mg a day for adult women generally, with no separate breastfeeding figure in the primary table. The NIH international reference for breastfeeding is 310 mg a day (ages 19-30) or 320 mg a day (ages 31 and over) — the same as its standard adult-woman figure, since magnesium needs don't rise during breastfeeding the way several other nutrients in this series have. Rather than trying to calculate every milligram, focus on a dependable magnesium source most days.

If you are breastfeeding or expressing milk: If you're breastfeeding, magnesium continues to matter for your own muscle, nerve, and bone health as you recover.

If you are not breastfeeding: If you're not breastfeeding, magnesium remains important for your own recovery — your target is the general adult figure above.

Where magnesium comes from: Magnesium leans toward plant foods — nuts, seeds, legumes, and whole grains carry meaningfully more than most animal foods. If you eat meat, fish, or eggs, they can make a modest contribution, but they generally provide much less magnesium than nuts, seeds, legumes, and whole grains. Pairing an animal-food meal with one of these plant sources makes the week's magnesium focus more dependable.

About migraines: If migraines are a real issue for you, there's genuine — though not definitive — evidence that supervised magnesium supplementation can help prevent them. The doses studied for migraine prevention often exceed the usual upper limit for magnesium from supplements, so this is something to discuss with your doctor rather than begin on your own.

A gentle note for this week: The upper limit for magnesium — 350 mg a day — applies only to magnesium from supplements and medications, not to magnesium from ordinary food, which hasn't been shown to cause harm in people with healthy kidneys. Magnesium-containing supplements, antacids, and laxatives can interact with certain antibiotics and oral bisphosphonates — the required spacing differs by medicine, so follow the product instructions or confirm timing with your pharmacist. These products can also cause diarrhoea or abdominal cramping, especially at higher doses.

This week's rhythm: One dependable magnesium source most days — a serving of nuts, seeds, legumes, or whole grains — adds up more than trying to maximize it at any single meal.

Each day below offers two options, and both are built to carry this week's nutrient — you don't need to mix and match to get a genuine magnesium source. Choose whichever suits you today — there's no 'right' path between A and B.

If you are managing a health condition

- **Thyroid condition:** Ordinary magnesium-rich food does not require special spacing from levothyroxine. Like several other mineral supplements in this series, a magnesium supplement or magnesium-containing antacid is often best taken a few hours apart from levothyroxine — check timing with your clinician or pharmacist.
- **Kidney disease:** Kidney disease changes how your body handles magnesium, and the risk of it building up to unsafe levels is genuinely higher if kidney function is reduced. Follow your renal team's specific guidance on both food and any supplement — this is one of the few nutrients in this series where that guidance may differ meaningfully from general advice.
- **High blood pressure or previous pre-eclampsia:** Studies suggest magnesium supplementation only modestly lowers blood pressure, and it isn't a substitute for your prescribed monitoring and medicines. Continue your care team's plan as usual; ordinary food sources don't need special adjustment.
- **Diabetes, recent gestational diabetes, or PCOS:** Some studies link higher magnesium intake with better long-term blood sugar patterns, but the American Diabetes Association states there isn't enough evidence to recommend magnesium specifically for glycemic control. The foods this week are fine to include as part of your usual eating plan.

Day 1 — Anchor

This week's nutrient works quietly in the background — muscle and nerve signals, a steady heartbeat, energy release from food. Both choices below carry a real magnesium source, not just one of them.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable oats porridge with a tablespoon of pumpkin or sesame seeds.
- B. Peanut butter on whole-wheat toast with a banana.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a small bowl of rajma curry and a small bowl of curd.
- B. Chicken curry (cooked through) with a boiled-potato (with skin, scrubbed well) side and rice.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small handful of almonds and cashews.
- B. Roasted chana with a small guava.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Dal (½–1 small bowl), roti, and a bhindi (okra) sabzi.
- B. Grilled or pan-cooked fish — a locally available lower-mercury variety — with brown rice.

If you're still hungry: Whatever's easiest to reach for right now.

Worth knowing: When eating potato with the skin on, scrub it well first. Discard potatoes that have turned green, taste bitter, or are heavily sprouted, as these may contain higher levels of natural compounds called glycoalkaloids, including solanine.

Day 2 — The claims worth being careful about

Magnesium gets talked about for cramps, sleep, and mood more confidently than the evidence actually supports — worth a closer, honest look this week.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable dalia with a small bowl of curd, and a banana.
- B. Masala omelette (fully cooked, yolk included) with whole-wheat toast and avocado.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a small bowl of chana curry.
- B. Mutton-and-vegetable curry with whole-wheat roti and a small cucumber salad containing approximately one tablespoon of roasted sesame seeds.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A tablespoon of roasted sesame seeds with a small guava.
- B. A glass of soymilk with a handful of peanuts.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal (½–1 small bowl), roti, and a lauki (bottle gourd) sabzi.
- B. Paneer-and-spinach curry with roti, and a small handful of roasted peanuts on the side.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

About cramps, sleep, and mood: You may have heard magnesium suggested for muscle cramps, sleep, or mood. The evidence for cramps specifically is mixed and generally low quality — some small trials show a modest benefit, others show none, and it isn't strong enough to present magnesium as a reliable fix. There isn't good evidence that dietary magnesium improves sleep or mood on its own. If cramps, sleep, or mood are a real struggle for you, that's worth raising with your care team rather than something to solve through this week's food choices alone.

If you received magnesium during labor or delivery: If you received magnesium sulfate during labor or delivery — commonly used for pre-eclampsia or to help protect a premature baby's brain — that was a different, much higher clinical dose given by IV. It doesn't change what you need from food now.

Day 3 — Where magnesium naturally shows up

Nuts, seeds, legumes, whole grains, and even some everyday vegetables all contribute — this nutrient doesn't hide in one hard-to-reach food group.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable upma with cashews mixed in.
- B. Egg-and-vegetable roll (fully cooked) with a side of roasted peanuts.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a small bowl of masoor dal curry, and a small bowl of curd.
- B. Pan-cooked fish — a locally available lower-mercury variety — with a bajra roti and a cooked spinach side.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A banana with a small handful of almonds.
- B. Roasted chana with an orange.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Dal ($\frac{1}{2}$ –1 small bowl), roti, and a cabbage sabzi.
- B. Chicken curry (cooked through) with whole-wheat roti and a sesame-spinach side.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

Day 4 — A nutrient most diets already lean toward

Magnesium doesn't depend on animal food at all. Beans, nuts, seeds, and whole grains can make a meaningful contribution, whether you eat animal foods or not — the amount still depends on the foods, portions, and how often you reach for them.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Moong-and-vegetable cheela with a tomato-onion side, and a banana.
- B. Oats or a whole-grain cereal with milk and a spoonful of crushed almonds or sesame seeds.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a small bowl of chana-and-vegetable curry.
- B. Bajra roti with a black-eyed-pea (lobia) curry.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small handful of mixed seeds and cashews.
- B. Roasted peanuts with a small guava.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal ($\frac{1}{2}$ –1 small bowl), roti, and a boiled-potato (with skin, scrubbed well) sabzi.
- B. Rajma with jowar roti.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

Day 5 — Away from home

Nuts, roasted chana, and a piece of fruit are easy, portable ways to keep this week's focus going on a busy day.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. A pre-made peanut-butter-and-banana sandwich, carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten.
- B. A pre-made egg sandwich (fully cooked egg), carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten, with a small handful of peanuts.

Lunch — choose one:

- A. A rajma-and-vegetable wrap, carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten.
- B. A chicken roll, made with fully cooked chicken and a cucumber side containing a small handful of peanuts, carried in an insulated bag with an ice pack, kept cold until eaten.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. Roasted almonds and cashews, kept portable.
- B. A small bowl of curd, kept in an insulated bag with an ice pack and kept cold until eaten, with a guava and a spoonful of crushed peanuts or almonds.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. A reheated chana-and-vegetable curry with rice.
- B. A reheated fish curry — a locally available lower-mercury variety — with rice and a boiled-potato (with skin, scrubbed well) side.

If you're still hungry: Whatever's already within reach.

Food safety: Keep the sandwiches, wrap, roll, and curd all refrigerated or in an insulated bag with an ice pack, and make sure they stay cold until you actually eat them — discard anything that's been sitting out at room temperature for more than about two hours (about one hour in hot weather). Reheat the chana curry or fish curry until steaming hot before eating.

Day 6 — Small, steady habits continue

Same idea as the past few weeks — one dependable magnesium source most days, whether that's a nut, a seed, a legume, or a whole grain, placed steadily through your week.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Besan cheela with a small bowl of curd.
- B. Paneer paratha with one tablespoon of roasted sesame seeds (til).

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Whole-wheat roti with a small bowl of rajma curry, and an orange on the side.
- B. Chicken stew (cooked through) with whole-wheat roti and a sesame-and-spinach side.

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A tablespoon of mixed seeds with an orange.
- B. A boiled egg with a handful of peanuts.

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Dal (½–1 small bowl), roti, and a French beans sabzi.
- B. Chana with jowar roti.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack.

Day 7 — Reflection

A quiet week to notice what already felt manageable, and what you'd want to carry into the weeks ahead.

Breakfast: Whichever breakfast felt best this week — worth repeating.

Lunch: Whichever lunch from this week you'd want again.

Nourishment break: Whichever snack worked best for you this week.

Dinner: Whichever dinner from this week you'd want again.

If you're still hungry: A familiar snack, whatever suits you.

Still in Rebuilding — the phase that began last week. Small, steady sources, chosen consistently, do more for you here than any single perfect meal.

Gentle weekly reflection

Did anything about this week's foods surprise you — anything already a regular part of your meals?

Looking ahead

Next week, we'll look at another nutrient as you continue rebuilding your own strength.

Food safety basics

- Cook eggs, meat, and fish all the way through — no runny yolks or pink centres.
- Cook sprouts before eating them. Raw sprouts carry a real risk of bacteria that washing doesn't remove — skip them raw entirely.
- Choose pasteurized milk, curd, and paneer.
- Wash fruits and vegetables well.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. If the source is uncertain, boil it or use a purifier suitable for the local water risk, and avoid ice from unknown sources when eating out.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding, unless your maternity team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding. If you choose to drink, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose lower-mercury fish and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.